

Fallen Angels

doc-fallen-angels

Angelology · Fallen Angels · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants not in scope

Statement under examination

A portion of the angels fell into rebellion under Satan and are now demons opposed to God.

In plain language

Several New Testament passages directly attach the language of sin and rebellion to angels (angeloi) and then describe their judgment in plain grammatical terms. In 2 Peter 2:4 the participle translated 'sinned' (hamartesan, from G0264) is predicated of (asserted about) angels (angeloi), and the main verbs say God did not spare them but cast them into 'gloom' (zophos), having handed them over to be kept for judgment. The verse uses 'cast into Tartarus' (tartaroo, G5020), a one-occurrence word (a hapax, meaning it appears only once in the entire New Testament) found nowhere else, so the picture is locked to this one event rather than a generic image. Jude 6 runs parallel: angels who did not keep their own domain but 'abandoned' (apolipontas, G0620) their proper dwelling are now held in 'everlasting' (aidios) bonds under darkness for the judgment of the great day. 'Everlasting' (aidios) appears in the New Testament only here and in Romans 1:20 of God's eternal power, so its sense here is calibrated against that one controlled pair, and the bonds are real. Matthew 25:41 has Jesus himself speak of 'eternal' (aionios) fire prepared for the devil and his angels (angeloi), where the possessive 'his' attaches a body of angels to the chief adversary and assigns them his sentence. Revelation 12:7-9 narrates 'war' (polemos) in heaven in which the dragon and his angels fight Michael and his angels, after which the great dragon, the ancient serpent called the devil and Satan, is cast down to earth with his angels. Four labels are explicitly equated for the same antagonist (dragon, ancient serpent, devil, Satan), and a co-cast cohort follows him. Ephesians 6:12 names organized hostile spirit-powers, the rulers, authorities, and world-rulers of this darkness in the heavenly places, corroborating the picture even though it does not itself call them angels. The vocabulary is consistent across gospel, epistle, and apocalyptic, the subjects are stated, and the grammar does not bend to a figurative reading without recategorizing explicit predication (direct assertion). Old Testament passages sometimes brought in (Isaiah 14 on the king of Babylon, Ezekiel 28 on the king of Tyre) address human kings in their immediate context, so they are treated as at most corroborative and the verdict does not depend on them. Variant readings in 2 Peter 2:4 (chains versus pits) and Revelation 12 word order do not touch the predication of sin to angels.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0126	αἰδιος	aidios	eternal	2
G0166	αἰώνιος	aionios	eternal	71
G0264	ἁμαρτάνω	hamartano	to sin	44
G0620	ἀπολείπω	apoleipo	to leave	9
G0744	ἀρχαῖος	archaios	ancient	12
G1199	δεσμός	desmos	chain	19

G1228	διάβολος	diabolos	devilish/the Devil	38
G1404	δράκων	drakon	dragon	13
G1849	ἐξουσία	exousia	authority	103
G2032	ἐπουράνιος	epouranios	heavenly	19
G2147	εὑρέθη	ehuriskō	to find/meet	
G2217	ζόφος	zophos	darkness	5
G2480	ἰσχυσεν	ischuō	be strong	
G2888	κοσμοκράτωρ	kosmokrator	world power	1
G2920	κρίσις	krisis	judgment	48
G3789	ὄφις	ophis	snake	16
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	123
G4170	πολεμέω	polemeo	to fight	7
G4567	Σατανᾶς	Satanas	Satan	37
G5020	ταρταρόω	tartaroo	hell	1

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Three independent New Testament texts directly attach sin and rebellion vocabulary to angels (angeloi) and pair it with judicial confinement (legal lock-up awaiting trial). 2 Peter 2:4 uses 'having sinned' (hamartesan ton, an aorist active participle, a completed past action in participle form, of G0264) of angels (angeloi), and the verb 'cast into Tartarus' (tartaroo, G5020, a hapax meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament) describes God casting them into 'gloom' or 'deep darkness' (zophos, G2217). Jude 6 in parallel uses 'did not keep' (me terasantas) of their 'domain' or 'original position' (archen) and 'having abandoned' (apolipontas, G0620) of their 'dwelling' or 'proper habitation' (oiketerion), with the result that they are kept in 'everlasting bonds' (aidios desmos, G0126 plus G1199) under 'gloom' (zophos) 'for judgment' (eis krisin). Matthew 25:41 names eternal fire prepared for the 'devil' (diabolos) and 'his angels' (tois angelois autou), and Revelation 12:7-9 narrates 'war' (polemos) in heaven in which 'the dragon' (ho drakon) and his 'angels' (angeloi) are cast down. The lexical pattern spans gospel, epistle, and apocalyptic genres, and the grammar is not ambiguous: sin and abandonment are predicated of (asserted about) angelic subjects.

Scripture

2Pet.2.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0264 ἁμαρτησάντων, G5020 τάρταρώσας, G2217 ζόφου, G2920 κρίσιν, G3860 παρέδωκεν

Force. The aorist active participle (a completed past action expressed in participle form) 'having sinned' (hamartesan ton) predicates sin directly of 'angels' (angeloi). The main verb chain runs 'did not spare, but having cast into Tartarus handed over to be kept for judgment' (ouk ephesato, alla tartarosas paredoken eis krisin teroumenous). The participle 'having cast into Tartarus' (tartarosas) is from 'cast into Tartarus' (tartaroo, G5020), a New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament) used here only, which makes the verse a lexical fingerprint rather than a generic image, and the entire grammar predicates the sin to the angelic subject without ambiguity.

Jude.1.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0620 ἀπολιπόντας, G0126 αἰδίοις, G1199 δεσμοῖς, G2217 ζόφον, G2920 κρίσιν

Force. 'Angels' (angeloi) who 'did not keep' (me terasantas) their own 'domain' or 'original position' (arche) but 'having abandoned' (apolipontas, G0620) their proper 'dwelling' (oiketerion) are now held in 'everlasting bonds' (aidios desmos, G0126 plus G1199) under 'gloom for judgment of the great day' (zophos eis krisin megales hemeras). Two complementary participles describe a willful failure to keep and a positive abandonment of station, followed by penal confinement (punitive lock-up). The judicial vocabulary, 'judgment' (krisis), 'bonds' (desmos), 'he has kept' (tetereken), is unmistakable, and 'everlasting' (aidios, G0126) occurs in the New Testament only here and in Romans 1:20 (of God's eternal power), so its sense here is calibrated against that controlled pair.

Matt.25.41 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1228 διαβόλω, G0166 αἰώνιον

Force. The 'eternal' (aionios) fire is 'prepared' (hetoimasmenon, a perfect passive participle, a completed action whose result still stands, in passive voice) 'for the devil and his angels' (toi diabolo kai tois angelois autou). The possessive 'his' (autou) attaches a body of 'angels' (angeloi) to the 'devil' (diabolos) as their chief and assigns them his appointed end. Christ himself speaks the line, giving the proposition pan-canonical reach (spread across the whole Bible) beyond the epistles.

Rev.12.7 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G4170 πολεμήσαι, G1404 δράκοντος

Force. 'There was war in heaven' (egeneto polemos en toi ourano). 'Michael and his angels to make war with the dragon, and the dragon fought and his angels' (Michael kai hoi angeloi autou tou polemesai meta tou drakontos, kai ho drakon epolemesen kai hoi angeloi autou). The grammar gives the 'dragon' (drakon) a parallel possessive cohort, 'his angels' (hoi angeloi autou), symmetrical with Michael's, presenting two organized angelic armies.

Rev.12.8 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2480 ἵσχυσεν, G2147 εὐρέθη

Force. 'And he did not prevail, nor was a place found for them any longer in heaven' (kai ouk ischusen, oude topos heurethe auton eti en toi ourano). The third person singular 'he prevailed' (ischusen) subject is the 'dragon' (drakon), while 'of them' (auton) is the genitive plural (the 'of-them' grammatical form) of the dragon's group, jointly losing place in heaven. The construction makes the dragon and his 'angels' (angeloi) a single defeated party.

Rev.12.9 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G1404 δράκων, G0744 ἀρχαῖος, G3789 ὄφης, G1228 Διάβολος, G4567 Σατανᾶς

Force. 'The great dragon was cast down, the ancient serpent, the one called Devil and Satan' (eblethe ho drakon ho megas, ho ophis ho archaios, ho kaloumenos Diabolos kai ho Satanas). Four labels are explicitly equated by appositional articles (linking 'the' words that put names side by side as the same person): 'dragon' (drakon), 'ancient serpent' (ophis archaios), 'Devil' (Diabolos), 'Satan' (Satanas). 'And his angels were cast down with him' (kai hoi angeloi autou met autou eblethesan). The text identifies one antagonist by four lexical handles and assigns him a co-cast cohort of 'angels' (angeloi).

Eph.6.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1849 ἐξουσίας, G2032 ἐπουρανίους, G2888 κοσμοκράτορας

Force. 'Our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the world-rulers of this darkness, against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places' (ouk estin hemin he pale pros haima kai sarka, alla pros tas archas, pros tas exousias, pros tous kosmokratoras tou skotous toutou, pros ta pneumatika tes ponerias en tois epouraniois). Four prepositional phrases enumerate hostile spirit categories with 'world-ruler' (kosmokrator, G2888) a New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament). The phrase 'in the heavenly places' (en tois epouraniois) places them in a heavenly sphere, lexically aligned with the 'angels' (angeloi) described elsewhere as cast from heaven, but the verse does not itself name them 'angels' (angeloi), so it corroborates rather than carries the verdict.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
2Pet.2.4	2Pet.2.9	tsk	1
2Pet.2.4	Isa.14.12	tsk	1
2Pet.2.4	Job.4.18	tsk	1
Matt.25.41	Matt.7.23	tsk	1
Eph.6.12	Eph.2.2	tsk	1
Rev.12.9	Rev.9.1	tsk	1
Rev.12.9	Rev.20.2	tsk	1
Rev.12.9	Job.1.7	tsk	1
Rev.12.7	Rev.13.7	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Isa.14.12 · addressed

The Hebrew 'shining one, son of dawn' (heylel ben shachar, H1966) is a Hebrew hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Hebrew Bible), found only here. The immediate context (Isaiah 14:4) addresses a 'taunt-song' (mashal) against the 'king of Babylon' (melek Babel). The lexical evidence for an angelic-fall reading depends on identifying the king as a cipher for Satan, which the words alone do not force. The verdict on doc-fallen-angels does not rest on Isaiah 14. It rests on the explicit New Testament vocabulary in 2 Peter 2:4, Jude 6, Matthew 25:41, and Revelation 12:7-9, which name angelic subjects directly.

Ezek.28.12 · addressed

The 'lament' (qinah) is addressed 'to the king of Tyre' (melek tsor) in the immediate framing, with cherub-imagery and Eden language complicating the referent. The lexical material does not by itself rank a primary angelic referent over the human king. Like Isaiah 14, it is treated as corroborative at most. The verdict carries on the explicit New Testament predications, not on this disputed Old Testament layer.

Job.4.18 · addressed

Eliphaz says God charges his angels with 'folly' or 'error' (toholah). The speaker is a friend of Job whose theology is later challenged by God in Job 42:7, so the verse is unsafe to use as standalone doctrine. It is invoked here only as a cross-reference, not as a load-bearing anchor.

Eph.6.12 · addressed

Ephesians 6:12 names 'rulers' (archai), 'authorities' (exousiai), 'world-rulers' (kosmokratoras), and 'spiritual forces of evil' (pneumatika tes ponerias), but does not call them 'angels' (angeloi) or assert their origin in a fall. It is suggestive of organized hostile spirit-powers in the heavenly places, and corroborates the existence of an arrayed adversary, but the angelic-fall claim itself is carried by 2 Peter 2:4, Jude 6, Matthew 25:41, and Revelation 12:7-9 where 'angels' (angeloi) is on the page.

Gen.6.2 · addressed

The phrase 'sons of God' (bene ha-elohim) taking 'daughters of men' (benoth ha-adam) is read by some as an early angelic fall narrative, partly because of the juxtaposition in Jude 6 and 7. The Hebrew 'sons of God' (bene ha-elohim) is ambiguous lexically: it is used of angelic beings in Job 1:6 and Job 2:1 but also of Sethite human descent (the line of Seth) in older readings. The verdict does not depend on resolving Genesis 6:2, only on the explicit New Testament predications, so the ambiguity is noted and left as a complicating text.

Concordance traversed

G0264, G0620, G2217, G0126, G1199, G1228, G0166, G1404, G4170, G1849, G2032, G0744, G2920, G5020, G3789, G4567, G2888, G3860

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

seirais-vs-sirois at 2Pet.2.4: impact none. Some manuscripts read 'chains' (seirais, G4577) while others read 'pits' (sirois, related to seiros). 'Chains' (G4577) is a New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament) found only at 2 Peter 2:4 either way. Whether chains or pits, the construction 'kept reserved for judgment' (teroumenous eis krisin) remains and the predication (assertion) of sin to 'angels' (angeloi) is untouched, so the variant does not move the verdict.

rev-12-7-word-order at Rev.12.7: impact none. Minor word-order differences in the war-in-heaven clause do not affect the two parallel possessive cohorts (Michael and his 'angels' (angeloi), the dragon and his 'angels' (angeloi)) nor the casting-down result in Revelation 12:9. The verdict holds across the variant readings.

These verses fall outside the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) scope; the only ingested ECM window is 3 John 1:1 to 1:15. The verdict-relevant readings are stable across the standard New Testament critical texts.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

grammatico-historical: affirms · Direct predication of 'to sin' (hamartano) to 'angels' (angeloi) in 2 Peter 2:4, plus 'did not keep' (me teresantas) and 'having abandoned' (apoliPontas) of their 'domain' (arche) and 'dwelling' (oiketerion) in Jude 6, grammatically assert angelic sin and abandonment of station. Revelation 12:7-9 narrates the 'dragon' (drakon) and his 'angels' (angeloi) cast down, and Matthew 25:41 has 'eternal' (aionios) fire prepared for the devil and his 'angels' (angeloi). The grammar does not leave room for a metaphorical reading without violating the cited subjects.

redemptive-historical: affirms · Across the canon the ancient serpent of Genesis 3 is identified as the 'dragon' (drakon), 'ancient serpent' (ophis archaios), 'Devil' (Diabolos), and 'Satan' (Satanas) in Revelation 12:9, and the eternal fire of Matthew 25:41 is prepared for the devil and his 'angels' (angeloi), tracing an arc of angelic rebellion and reserved judgment that closes in Revelation 20:10.

minimalist-mythopoetic: complicates · A minority reading takes the 'dragon' (drakon) and his 'angels' (angeloi) in Revelation 12 as imagery for human-political opposition (Roman empire, persecutors) and treats 2 Peter 2:4 and Jude 6 as drawing on intertestamental Watchers tradition (the between-testaments stories of fallen angelic Watchers, in 1 Enoch, frequently quoted in Jude) rather than asserting a literal angelic fall. On this reading the

texts attest a tradition rather than ratify it. The reading is lexically defensible only by demoting 'having sinned' (hamartesan ton), 'having abandoned' (apolipontas), and the explicit 'angels' (angeloi) subjects to figurative use, which the genre alone (apocalyptic for Revelation 12) does not require for the epistles. The verdict does not adopt this lens but represents it fairly.

The proposition is reachable by ordinary grammatical sense of the cited verbs. The redemptive-historical reading (tracing the story of redemption across the canon) reinforces it. The minimalist reading is included to represent the minority lens fairly, but it requires reclassifying explicit predication (direct assertion) as figurative, which the lexical material does not compel.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem describes a portion of 'angels' (angeloi) falling into rebellion under Satan and now being demons opposed to God. The components angelic sin (2 Peter 2:4, Jude 6), a chief adversary commanding them (Revelation 12:7-9, Matthew 25:41), and present opposition (Ephesians 6:12) are each tied to explicit lexical anchors, so the stem is descriptive rather than tradition-loaded. The further identification of these fallen 'angels' (angeloi) specifically as 'demons' (daimonion, G1140) is an inference from the wider witness rather than from the cited verses themselves, but it does not preload the verdict on angelic rebellion, which holds whether or not the demon equation is granted.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Pet.2.4
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jude.1.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.12.9
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0264
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5020
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0620
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0126
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2888
syntax	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jude.1.6
syntax	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rev.12.7
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.25.41
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rev.12.9
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rev.12.9

License audit

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OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

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